Monday Nite Footballers

Commentary

By Jim Nunnelly

39th and Agnes: 'The Clyde Kemp Trail'

"Do not follow where the path may lead. Go instead where there is no path and leave a trail."

That quote seems to characterize Clyde Kemp. What's so special about Clyde Kemp? Is it that he worked nights at the Post Office? No. Or is it he's a regional loan specialist for HUD? No. Or is it that he's part of a family reunion that gives a scholarship to a fellow family member? No. Well, what's the big deal about this trail he leaves?

Simple.

Clyde just happens to be the winningest coach ever, in junior high Catholic League circles. And, though not recognized for his endless efforts, he's done this for twenty years—with little fanfare, just an uncontrollable obsession to serve. And he loves this coaching position and he shows you how much by the many stories he tells; like the one about an eighth grader who wanted to get married. Or about the fact that he's lost less than 50 games in his whole career. Or about the fact that he coached one "ghetto Catholic" now playing baseball with the Montreal Expos. On and on, like a proud history teacher who's just been honored. And teacher he is, let's look in.

For Clyde, entering the basketball coaching field was a complete accident. Not knowing a thing about basketball, he consented to sit with his son's team. This was way back in 1967, at little Blessed Sacrament School (now St. Martins) at 39th and Agnes. He was just to sit on the bench, not coach. Just act like a chaperone for a bunch of Catholic school kids who needed an adult to play. He started coaching that night and the rest is Clyde's history.

Over four hundred wins later, Clyde has convinced his whole family to get involved—his vivacious wife, Frankie, and his two sons. They all help and they're involved in the whole black Catholic movement, reinvesting themselves year after year.

But, Clyde's a Baptist convert. You'd never know it because his respect in the Catholic community is so profound and far reach-

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ing.

His confident influence ranges from spearheading the rules of the Catholic Sports Program to guiding the merger of inner city Catholic elementary schools. He's a rock and everyone around him knows it and they all expect him to be "solid and sound" in his judgments.

Especially, his players and the other 34 teams in the eighth grade Catholic League admire his coaching prowess. He just keeps winning championships year after year. Of course, he only tells you it's the "team" concept or it's the "fast break" that makes these junior high kids excel to impossible heights. But it's really Clyde's "dedication and drive" to make every young man a good student first and an athlete second. There it is, that's it, Clyde's key to his success. He pushes the developing youngster "to the max" and therein lies the "secret map" of the trail.

And he gets those results, too. Ask George Word. Or Cebron Robinson. Or Ricardo Broils. Or Anthony Augmon. Or Al Newman of the Montreal Expos. They all studied the basketball teachings of Clyde the Great. And from there went on to play college ball.

Speaking of study? Where did Clyde learn about basketball? As an intrusion into his privacy, he wasn't a basketball player in high school. And his speculative football playing days at Sumner in Kansas City, Kas., were cut short when his coach found his mother's signature was forged on a consent form. Further when reflecting back to his childhood days in Mississippi, he really dreamed of being a baseball player.

So how did it start? He learned from training films bought at Seven-Up sponsored clinics. Yes, that was years and many lessons ago.

Today, he still coaches the same eighth grade. And his Vince Lombardi-like style makes him trusted, feared and respected. Things have changed a little today, since way back in the 60's. Now his teams sport classy red and white uniforms. And he's been appointed to the Diocesan School Board. His wife, Frankie, is the cheerleader coach. And his two sons, even the one responsible for him coaching the 5th grade, share his coaching duties at the St. Martin de Porres School (formerly Blessed Sacrament.)

As if divinely guided, he smiles and says about his total involvement in this volunteer sports program, "we (his family) just feel like we need to be there". And kids, parents, school teachers, nuns, priests, bishops, coaches, all can find him every evening in the fall and winter, down at the Clyde Kemp trail.

Members of the Monday Nite Footballers are: Charles Allen, D.D.S., C. Ashley, Paul Booker, Tom Brown, Carl Clark, Ike Gardner, Jr., Ollie Hubbard, Jim Nunnelly, Jerry Price and Ed West.

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